AMCAT ADVANCED VERBAL

Reading & Inference

Mastering Critical Reasoning: Inference, Assumption & the Conclusion-Identifying Method

Inference Questions

Assumption Questions

Finding the Conclusion

SESSION ROADMAP

What We'll Cover Today

1. **The Core Distinction**

   Inference vs. Assumption — what each question type is really testing

2. **Conclusion-Identifying Method**

   A repeatable way to isolate the argument's actual claim

3. **Three Think-Aloud Examples**

   Full elimination reasoning, narrated step by step

4. **In-Class Activity**

   Independent practice, then a full walkthrough together

THE CORE DISTINCTION

Inference vs. Assumption

INFERENCE

What MUST be true, given only the passage.

- ✦ Reasons FROM stated facts to a certain conclusion
- ✦ Correct answer = a logical restatement or deduction
- ✦ “Likely”, “probably”, “could be” → not good enough
- ✦ Eliminate anything needing an extra assumption

ASSUMPTION

What the argument silently depends on to hold.

- ✦ Reasons UNDER the argument — the unstated bridge
- ✦ Correct answer is never written in the passage
- ✦ Test it: negate the option — does the conclusion collapse?
- ✦ If the argument survives the negation, it wasn't required

DEEP DIVE

Inference Questions

The rule: If an answer requires ANY extra fact, real-world guess, or plausible-but-unstated idea — eliminate it.

Elimination Checklist

✕	Goes beyond what the passage states?	Eliminate
✕	Only “likely” or “plausible”, not certain?	Eliminate
✕	Needs outside knowledge to be true?	Eliminate
✓	Can be derived with 100% certainty from the text?	Keep

DEEP DIVE

Assumption Questions

The Negation Test: Flip the option to its opposite. If the conclusion falls apart, it was an assumption.

Elimination Checklist

✕	It's a fact already stated in the passage?	Eliminate — it's a premise, not a gap
✕	It strengthens the argument but isn't required?	Eliminate
✕	It's broader or narrower than the argument needs?	Eliminate
✓	Negating it destroys the conclusion?	Keep — this is the assumption

Finding the Conclusion First

1. **Scan for signal words**

   "Thus", "therefore", "hence", "clearly", "so", "this shows" — these flag the claim.

2. **Locate the main claim**

   Often the last sentence — but it can sit first, or be buried in the middle.

3. **Separate claim from support**

   Set aside premises (evidence) and background/context; isolate the conclusion alone.

4. **Test options against the conclusion only**

   Not the whole passage — just the isolated claim.

5. **Eliminate off-target options**

   Options about premises or background, not the conclusion, are traps.

Read, Then Answer

Passage

All senior analysts at the firm hold an MBA. Ravi does not hold an MBA.

Which of the following must be true?

A Ravi is not a senior analyst.

B Ravi is a junior analyst.

C Ravi will never become a senior analyst.

D The firm prefers hiring candidates with an MBA.

EXAMPLE 1 · INFERENCE

Answer & Reasoning

CORRECT ANSWER

A

Ravi is not a senior analyst.

Elimination Reasoning — Think-Aloud

B **Eliminate** — Assumes only two job categories exist (junior/senior) — never stated. Extra assumption → out.

C **Eliminate** — Talks about the future (“will never”) — the passage says nothing about what could change later. Too strong.

D **Eliminate** — “Prefers hiring” is a claim about intent/policy — not stated anywhere. Plausible, not certain.

A **Keep** — Contrapositive of “all senior analysts hold an MBA”: if Ravi lacks an MBA, he cannot be a senior analyst. Follows with certainty.

Read, Then Answer

Argument

Online grocery delivery has grown 40% this year. Therefore, the city should build three new distribution warehouses to keep up with demand.

The argument above depends on which of the following assumptions?

A. Online grocery delivery will continue to grow at the same rate.

B. Existing distribution capacity cannot handle current or growing demand.

C. Building new warehouses is cheaper than renting existing storage space.

D. The city government has approved similar infrastructure projects before.

EXAMPLE 2 · ASSUMPTION

Answer & Reasoning

CORRECT ANSWER

B

Existing distribution capacity cannot handle current or growing demand.

Elimination Reasoning — Think-Aloud

A **Eliminate —** The conclusion is about current demand already seen (40% growth) — continued future growth isn't required for the argument to stand.

C **Eliminate —** Cost comparison isn't part of the argument at all — the conclusion never claims warehouses are the cheapest option.

D **Eliminate —** Past approvals are irrelevant to whether warehouses are actually needed now.

B **Keep —** Negation test: if existing capacity CAN handle demand, the case for new warehouses collapses entirely. The argument needs this to be true.

THINK-ALOUD EXAMPLE 3 · CONCLUSION-IDENTIFYING

Read, Then Answer

Passage

Several studies link high sugar consumption to type-2 diabetes risk. A recent study of 10,000 adults found that halving sugar intake cut diabetes risk by 15% over five years. Clearly, public health campaigns should prioritize sugar-reduction messaging over general calorie-counting advice, since the data shows a direct impact on disease outcomes. This approach could also reduce healthcare costs tied to diabetes treatment.

Which of the following, if true, would most weaken the argument?

A. Reducing calorie intake also lowers diabetes risk by a comparable amount.

B. Sugar-reduction campaigns cost more to run than calorie-counting campaigns.

C. Healthcare costs for diabetes have risen over the past decade.

D. The 10,000-adult study was funded by a health advocacy group.

Answer & Reasoning

CORRECT ANSWER

A

Reducing calorie intake also lowers diabetes risk by a comparable amount.

Elimination Reasoning — Think-Aloud

- • **Keep —** Step 1 — isolate the conclusion: “...campaigns should PRIORITIZE sugar-reduction OVER calorie-counting...” (signalled by “clearly”). The last sentence on healthcare cost is a side consequence, not the conclusion.
- B **Eliminate —** Addresses running cost, not effectiveness — doesn't touch the “which is better at reducing risk” comparison.
- C **Eliminate —** About historical cost trends — attacks the last sentence, not the isolated conclusion.
- D **Eliminate —** Questions study credibility — a mild dent, but doesn't directly address the sugar-vs-calorie comparison itself.
- A **Keep —** Directly attacks the isolated conclusion: if calorie-counting works just as well, there's no reason to PRIORITIZE sugar-reduction over it.

PRACTICE

In-Class Activity

Individual Timed Set

Work through the set independently, applying today's elimination methods.

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Critical Reasoning Questions

Mixed inference & assumption items — apply the checklists.

1

Reading Passage — 6 MCQs

One passage; find the conclusion first, then work the questions.

After the set: Trainer walks through every question with full reasoning — the same think-aloud, elimination-based approach used in today's examples.

KEY TAKEAWAYS

Three Habits for Every Passage

1. **Inference = certainty**

   If it needs an extra assumption to be true, it's wrong — no matter how reasonable it sounds.

2. **Assumption = the silent gap**

   Run the Negation Test: if negating an option breaks the conclusion, that's your answer.

3. **Isolate the conclusion first**

   Find it before reading the options — then test every option against that claim alone.